

calculate the quickest route to cover the complete floor without leaving any corner untouched. Dirt sensors direct the robot towards dirtier areas and increase the power proportionately to enable complete cleaning. Accelerometer and gyrometer help the robot to maintain its speed and direction. Stair detector keeps the robot safe from staircases. Charge sensor indicates dying battery, so the robot returns to the charging station to get charged.

Battery life and coverage capacity. Battery capacity determines the robot's caliber to cover a given area on a single charge. Larger premises (over 280sq.m) may require battery capacity of 2200mAh or above to cover the complete floor. Lower battery life will drain out the robot in the middle of the cleaning process. For smaller areas, a smaller battery capacity will suffice. Battery runtime is often indicated on the box and should preferably be 120 minutes or more. The coverage capacity of the robots is also marked separately. Tally the marked coverage with the extent of area you want to clean.

Mobile app or remote controlled. This feature lets you control your robot anytime, from anywhere. So you can start the robot to do cleaning and pause it as well. Mobile-/remote-controlled robot cleaners can be run on preset schedules. You can also run your robot while you are in office, if you have forgotten to schedule it in the first place.

Good-to-have features

Below-mentioned features will help your robot to serve you better.

Virtual device. If you want to keep your robot from getting stuck under a bed or hitting your pet's food bowl, or you want to add extra protection from staircases, a virtual device can be very handy. It is a separate accessory that creates a virtual barrier wherever placed, beyond which the robot will not travel.

Low noise. While this might not be important if you schedule the robot to clean while you're out, mechanical noises become very unsettling when you are around. Look out for a robot that has a noise level below 65 decibels.

Options in the market

A variety of robotic cleaners are available in the market, starting from around ₹ 10,000. Based on cleaning requirements and features, these robots can cost as high as ₹ 40,000. Some of the good options are listed below.

Exilient ReadyMaid is a mid-range robotic cleaner that is capable of dry as well as wet floor cleaning. It packs up to 120-minute runtime on single charge, 24W power consumption and covers area up to 280sq.m (3000 sq.ft). Priced at ₹ 18,000, it also comes with a virtual device and HEPA filter for particulate matters.

iRobot's Braava 390t helps in hard cleaning with a 210-minute runtime and effective navigation logic. It features auto-filtering power and auto-stop. The coverage area is limited to 93sq.m (1000sq.ft). The device is smartphone-application-compatible and costs about ₹ 25,000.

Milagrow's Blackcat 7.0 comes with a 2200mAh battery that can last for over two hours on a single charge. It has a 400ml dustbin and can cover an area of 325sq.m (3500sq.ft). Featuring an artificial intelligence system, this high-end robot costs ₹ 34,000.

Last but not the least

HEPA filter allows more effective dust cleaning. So, if your budget allows, ensure the robot cleaner has a HEPA filter. Also, check out its warranty period. Most vendors offer one-year warranty. Finally, after you buy a robot cleaner, don't forget that it requires regular weekly maintenance of parts like brushes, dustbin and mops. **EFY**

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